

Base-Building Field Guide

Grow a coalition from 10 to 10,000 — step by step.

Phase 1 — Identify Your Core (0–30 Days)

- Conduct 1:1 listening sessions with 20–30 community members. Ask: What keeps you up at night?
- Identify 5–10 relational leaders — people with existing trust in the community.
- Map informal networks: churches, barbershops, community centers, housing developments.
- Intake form: name, phone, email, neighborhood, top issue, skills/availability.
- Goal: 25 committed members who show up — not 500 names on a list.

Door-Knocking Script

Opening	"Hi, my name is [NAME] from IRN. We're talking to neighbors about [ISSUE]. Have 5 minutes?"
The Listen	"What's the biggest problem you're dealing with in this neighborhood right now?"
Connection	"Others we've talked to have the same experience. We're organizing to do something about it."
The Ask	"Will you come to a meeting next [DAY] at [PLACE]? Keeping it small — about 20 people."
The Close	"Can I get your number to remind you? Anyone else on this block I should talk to?"

Phase 2 — First Meetings (30–60 Days)

- Keep first meetings to 60–90 min, 20–40 people max. Larger is not better.
- Use go-around introductions: name, neighborhood, why you came.
- Present one specific injustice with evidence — a document, statistic, or story.
- Let people speak. Your job is to draw out leadership, not perform it.
- End with a specific next step and a specific ask for each person in the room.
- Follow up within 48 hours. Attendance drops 50% at meeting #2 without personal follow-up.

Phase 3 — Volunteer Pipeline

Build a clear pipeline with defined roles.

Role	Commitment	Responsibilities	Next Step
Supporter	1–2 hrs/mo	Sign petitions, attend rallies	Invite to meetup
Volunteer	4–8 hrs/mo	Phone bank, flyering, event help	Assign to committee
Organizer	10–20 hrs/mo	Leads 1:1s, runs meetings, recruits	Leadership training

Role	Commitment	Responsibilities	Next Step
Chapter Lead	20+ hrs/mo	Campaign ownership, coalition relationships	IRN certification

Phase 4 — Retention

- Celebrate wins publicly and specifically — name the people who made them happen.
- Give people ownership: let them name the campaign, design the flyer, lead the meeting.
- Track attendance. Personally call anyone who misses two meetings in a row.
- Host at least one social event (cookout, dinner) per quarter.

Intake Tracker

Name	Phone	Neighborhood	Top Issue	Role	Status

TIP: 30 committed people beat 300 disengaged ones every time. Build depth, not just breadth.